Proposal by Station of Commons

School of Listening — ZKM

Every school should have a laboratory to experiment, develop, play with, and implement new ideas and also new tools. A space where artists, designers, curators, cultural workers, creatice technologists, and participants at large can think together and produce new forms of sharing and learning. For the School of Listening, Station of Commons engages this laboratory process with the concept of narrow-casting inspired by pirate radio artist Tetsuo Kogawa. In his text A Radioart manifesto[1], Kogawa elaborates on radio as the most advanced art using electronics. More precisely, Kogawa foresaw the paranoid dream of digital technology and placed hope in the Internet (as a technology) to sketch very different things to happen. In a narrow-casting network, each station is both emitter and receiver within a local reach range. The computer can sample locally to proliferate the message at a translocal level, in opposition to global systems such as satellite. Echoing a material response to Brecht[2], narrow-casting together with Internet technology can potentially erase the positional difference between sender and receiver.

In this sense and at this point, Station of Commons proposes a first iteration to (re)activate the narrow-casting and translocal concepts using contemporary technology and readily available electronics. The proposal opens in three directions.

Practically, the installation in the exhibition space implements a network of multiple micro-computers serving as radio stations, that can relay an audio stream from one to another using Open-Source software with peer-to-peer functionalities. The exhibition visitors do not need to do anything with the software. For the visitor the entry point to the installation is a microphone; the stations diffuse the audio stream in specific locations in the exhibition space through directional speakers. In other words, the participant's voice is then narrow-cast in the exhibition space. As part of the technical and conceptual approach of Station of Commons, each station implements a specific latency in the audio stream. The voice input in the microphone is spatialized across the exhibition over time. Two issues need already to be stressed: first, the station never records anything, only relay a constant flux of audio. Second, the microphone needs to be activated on purpose. The work does not steal surrounding personal non-consented sound.

Listening is an act of attention and intention; voicing is a conscious and bodily act. The installation produces many situations of voicing and listening. The visitor can use the narrow-casting network to openly speak their mind to onlookers[4] in the space, walk to listen to their own voice message, tell friends what future message is coming up; use the audio stations to express things through sound otherwise. As much as the onlookers are for exhibition, the distributed voice occupies the space. The acts of voicing and listening become a concrete form of spatial reappropriation. In reference to Stavros Stavrides[5], voicing is a performative act of collective reappropriation in the contested space that is an exhibition in a public museum.

As mentioned earlier, the installation is a first iteration. We produce a version for the School of Listening. We consider this conceptual and technological design work always in the making, a digital commoning process. We aim to document the process also in a open repository for people who will like to tinker and experiment with it in their contexts.

Text based on notes from Station of Commons meetings in April/May/June/July/August 2026.

Notes

1. In the text, voicing is not an absolute term. Sound capture can range from voice to whistling, to clapping hands, knocking fingers on the table, tearing paper…

2. We consider directional speakers to produce a collective form of listening in specific locations. These locations are to be agreed upon

3. The station network does not need an Internet connection.

4. The microphone is activated by a manual push button, activated by the participant.

5. The micro-computers Raspberry Pi can be acquired with SoC budget; however, the sound capture and diffusion can be handled by ZKM's own resources.

References

[1] Kogawa, T. (2008). A radioart manifesto. In Acoustic.Space nr. 7: SPECTROPIA — illuminating investigations in the electromagnetic spectrum (pp. 128–135). RIXC.
https://radioart.jp/20080710AcousticSpaceIssue_7.html

[2] Brecht, B. (2000). The radio as a communications apparatus (M. Silberman, Trans.). In Bertolt Brecht on film and radio (pp. 41–45). Methuen. (Original work published 1932)

[3] RaspberryPi is small computer, the size of a pack of cigarettes, price at 150€.

[4] In this situation, one may agree to say Inlisteners.

[5] https://www.stationofcommons.org/events/digital-commoning-practices-archives/

Process & Materials

- **Microcomputers (Raspberry PI)** x 150 Euros x 5 = 750 euros
- **WiFi Dongle** x5
- **Push Buttons** x5
- **Microphones** x5
- **Audio adapters for RPI5** x5
- **Circular Led Stripes** x5
- **3D Printed Raspberry PI Case** x5

Development (15.10 – 15.11)

- Software development for 2 modules
- Hardware testing
- Latency testing

Prototyping (December)

- Design the 3D housing with button integrated (is this possible to print ZKM?)
- Production of the rest of the modules based on the chosen prototypes for this iteration.

Documentation (December)

- Github or other

Installation (January)